

Phase 5: Self-Sabotage – The Internal Barrier

“We are not punished for our sins, but by them.”

— Elbert Hubbard

You may feel a familiar sinking in your chest as you read these words—the weight of disappointment with yourself. Perhaps your shoulders slump, or a quiet shame begins to coil in your belly. This is the body remembering every goal abandoned, every opportunity avoided, every promise broken. **But what if this pattern was never about weakness?**

You know the cycle: you set a goal, you start strong, and then... something happens. You procrastinate. You overcomplicate. You find a reason to stop just before the finish line. This is not weakness—it is **protection**. Every act of self-sabotage carries a hidden positive intent, a function it once served in keeping you safe.

Internal Family Systems (IFS) therapy reveals that these self-destructive parts are **protectors**—exiled managers working overtime to prevent a greater perceived catastrophe. Perhaps staying small keeps you safe from the criticism that would come with visibility. Perhaps failing on your own terms feels better than risking genuine rejection. Perhaps success means abandoning the family system that raised you.

The body holds these protective contracts in its tissue. Clenched shoulders carry the weight of over-responsibility. A collapsed chest guards against the vulnerability of being seen. Chronic tension in the legs prevents forward movement. Until we address sabotage **somatically**—interrupting the physical pattern, not just the cognitive thought—we remain trapped in loops of understanding without change. In this phase, we create pattern interrupts at the level of the nervous system, where real transformation lives.

In this phase, you will:

- Identify your unique sabotage patterns and their bodily signatures
- Discover the hidden “positive intent” and protective function beneath them

- Create somatic pattern interrupts that break the cycle at the physical level
- Build new neural pathways through embodied repetition